

Don't allow Big Brother to watch you!

I asked RMS why he doesn't carry a cell phone. He said there were several reasons for that. First, cell phones have a lot of proprietary stuff inside them. Second, he doesn't want "big brother" keeping an eye on where he is travelling. He also said that since most of the stuff on cell phones is proprietary, we don't know if there are back doors and the companies are gathering information about us.



The reason for being a bit anxious was that RMS doesn't carry a cell phone. Now, I was thirsty and needed water, but I couldn't leave the spot as he might have just passed by and taken a pre-paid taxi. There was no means to contact him and let him know that I was around. I would later ask him why he didn't carry a cell phone. Right then, my eyes searched for him and his friend Dora.

Then I caught a glimpse of the man and I felt an adrenalin rush. He was coming through a glass door, wearing his typical red T-shirt and Dora was by his side. He came out and started walking towards the taxi stand. I yelled "RMS!" He did not hear me. I yelled again and he heard. He came to me. I told him who I was and that I was there to pick him up. I made a call to the cab driver to come and pick us up.

We walked towards the main road. The driver was there and told us that it would be better if we walked to the taxi. He took the trolley from RMS, who hesitated and I said it was okay. At this point he said, "Look, that is the problem with the caste system in India—we are not even allowed to carry our own stuff." He is a critic of the caste system in India and I learned about his concerns other than just free software, which reminded me of *The White Tiger*, Adiga's award-winning book that I had just finished reading. While I tried to talk about several things, he stopped me, saying, "I can't understand what you are saying, please speak slowly." I controlled my excitement, explaining that I was from *LINUX For You* magazine. To which he responded that the name of the magazine is not okay! Well, that is something we can't do anything about now, unfortunately.

We sat in the cab and started towards the guest house at JNU (Jawaharlal Nehru University). On the way he asked me to stop by somewhere and get some water. We found some shops open. While I was about to leave to get the water, he told me, "Make sure its not any of the Coca Cola products because we have boycotted them." Oh! Now, it was already midnight, there was only this one shop open and RMS had put forward this condition. I didn't know anything about the reason behind the boycott, but I decided to keep my questions for later and headed for the shop.

There I learned that they only had Coca Cola's brand of mineral water. I returned empty handed. And that was the second time I came face to face with this man's idealism—he'd rather choose to stay thirsty than drink a

drop of Coke's water. I then asked why he had boycotted the company. He replied that it was because the company used paramilitaries to murder union organizers at Coca Cola bottling plants in Colombia, South America. Now, who ever said that RMS was only concerned about one issue (Linus Torvalds wrote that in one of his recent blogs) proved to be absolutely wrong.

We reached the guest house, but did not find any other shops where we could get water from. At the guest house I offered to try elsewhere, but by then Dora pulled out some small water bottles from her bag and said that they could survive till morning. I bid them a good night and told them I'd pick them up the next morning for a Sun Microsystems' event at IIT Delhi that RMS was going to be a part of. Jaijit Bhattacharya, a good friend and country director, government strategy, Sun Microsystems, was organising the event and had planned RMS's visit to New Delhi.

The next morning we went to IIT where RMS was to inaugurate the Center for Excellence in E-Governance. There he needed to do some mail transfers, and then I realised why sometimes it could take around 24 hours to get his replies. He pulled all the mails from the server onto his small and cute Lemote laptop and then pushed the mails that he had already answered. Then he started answering the mails he had pulled down.

Most of the time he kept working on his laptop, but was always willing to talk and respond to people no matter what they asked. While inside the hall, he noticed the word 'Open Source' associated with the event and got a bit upset. He wanted to talk to Jaijit immediately. I connected them and then he took a promise from Jaijit that they would support the cause of free software. Even during the lamp-lighting ceremony, he said that he was doing this based on a promise from Jaijit that they would support the cause. Ah, I forgot to mention that it was around 12 pm, and RMS and Dora had not had any breakfast. Later, I would learn that he skips breakfast or even lunch if there is work. Well, I've never seen this kind of dedication.

After the inauguration, we had to attend another event—a panel discussion on Policies for Sustainable Absorption of ICT in Society. I got a bit worried to see Windows XP running on the laptop connected to the projector. I told the organisers that it could create some problems and if they wanted they could use my laptop, which runs Ubuntu. They showed their unwillingness to cooperate by saying that it was not possible to switch in the middle of a session. I asked them to hide the Windows XP logo hanging on the screen. I did not want RMS to be photographed speaking against the backdrop of Windows XP.

Someone conveyed that message to Jaijit who was anchoring the show, and they put an obstacle between the lens and the screen. All this time RMS was sitting on a sofa on the stage and reading a book. I thought he was not